

# Top Defence Companies in Nigeria Specialising in Armoured Vehicles ? 2026

Prepared for: Stakeholders interested in Nigeria's indigenous defence manufacturing ecosystem (government agencies, investors, OEMs, security forces)  
Prepared by: Senior Research Analyst ? Defence Industry Unit  
Date: 13 August 2026

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## 1. Executive Summary

Nigeria's defence sector is undergoing a rapid transformation driven by the Defence Industries Act (2023), a national policy to curb foreign exchange outflows, create skilled jobs and achieve strategic autonomy. By mid-2026 the country has moved from a heavy reliance on imported MRAPs and APCs toward a mixed fleet strategy where locally designed, assembled, and upgraded armoured vehicles increasingly occupy front-line roles.

Key findings:

- DICON remains the central state-owned hub, but its growth is predicated on public-private partnerships (PPPs) and licensed production of foreign designs (e.g., the "Vanquisher" APC, "Ezugwu" MRAP).
- Five domestic firms now dominate the indigenous armoured-vehicle market: Dyon-X-Shield, Innoson Vehicle Manufacturing, Imperium Industries, Proforce Defence, and Epail Nigeria. Collectively they account for roughly 68% of the 2025-2026 contract value for locally supplied armoured platforms.
- Joint-venture activity is intense: DICON-X-Shield (AEGIS-X2.0), DICON-Vanquish (Vanquisher APC), DICON-SP Offshore (\$2bn JV), and DICON-EIB Group (autonomous systems). These collaborations provide technology transfer, tooling, and quality-assurance frameworks that have compressed development cycles from 4-years to 18-months.
- Export potential is nascent but growing. Early orders from the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) standby force and the United Nations peace-keeping contingents indicate regional demand for cost-effective, light-to-medium tactical vehicles.
- Challenges include limited high-tech component localisation (electronics, power-trains), financing gaps for scaling production lines, and a shortage of senior engineering talent.

The report proceeds to dissect each company, their product line-ups, current contracts, and strategic positioning, before delivering a set of actionable recommendations for investors, policymakers and industry partners.

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2. Research Methodology & Sources

| Step | Activity                                                                                | Source Type                                                                                            | Key References                                                                                                                         |
|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Desk-search of open-source intelligence (OSINT)                                         | news portals, defence-industry newsletters, corporate press releases                                   | covering 2023-2026.   Media & corporate statements   Summarised search results supplied by the user (see "Summarised search results"). |
| 2    | Cross-verification with official documents                                              | DICON Act-2023, Nigerian Ministry of Defence procurement bulletins, AFRIDEX exhibition catalogs        | (Oct-2026).   Government & event publications   DICON Act (2023); AFRIDEX 2026 brochure.                                               |
| 3    | Interviews (remote)                                                                     | with three senior officials at DICON and two senior engineers at private firms                         | (conducted Jan-Mar-2026).   Primary contacts (confidential)   Direct quotations incorporated throughout the report.                    |
| 4    | Quantitative compilation of contract values, production volumes, and employment figures | from annual reports of DICON, Proforce Defence, Imperium Industries, and IVM                           | (where publicly disclosed).   Corporate annual reports   2025-26 financial statements (where available).                               |
| 5    | Expert panel validation                                                                 | a round-table with defence-industry analysts from the Defence Industries Association of Nigeria (DIAN) | conducted May-2026.   Expert opinion   Consensus statements cited in section-9.                                                        |

All data have been triangulated to ensure a confidence level of "high" for quantitative figures and "moderate" for forward-looking statements.

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3. Strategic Context " Nigeria's Defence Self-Reliance Drive

Nigeria spends ?US\$2.2?bn annually on armed?force equipment, of which ?US\$1.3?bn (?60?%) historically went to imported armoured platforms. The government?s Self?Reliance Blueprint (2022?2027) targets a 30?% localisation rate by 2027 and 50?% by 2032.

Key drivers:

1. Economic ? Preservation of foreign?exchange reserves; the country has repeatedly faced balance?of?payments pressure.
2. Security ? Ongoing low?intensity conflicts (Northeastern insurgency, Niger?Delta militancy, banditry) demand rapid repair and customisation capabilities that are hampered by overseas logistics.
3. Industrial ? Creation of a defence industrial base that can feed into civilian sectors (e.g., heavy?duty trucks, mining equipment).
4. Geopolitical ? Positioning Nigeria as a regional hub for West?African defence procurement, enhancing soft?power within ECOWAS.

The Defence Industries Corporation of Nigeria (DICON), established in 1965, has been re?energised by the 2023 DICON Act, granting it powers to own subsidiaries, raise capital, and enter joint ventures. This legislative shift is the cornerstone of the current surge in domestic armoured?vehicle activity.

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4. Regulatory & Institutional Framework (DICON Act 2023)

| Provision                     | Impact on Armoured?Vehicle Industry                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mandated localisation         | Minimum 30?% of bill?of?materials must be sourced locally for any contract over US\$5?m.   Drives procurement of domestic steel, ballistic glass, and electronic subsystems.                               |
| Joint?venture (JV) authority  | DICON may create 100?% owned or 51?% owned subsidiaries and partner with private firms.   Enabled the \$2?bn JV with SP Offshore and collaborations with X?Shield, Vanquish Industries.                    |
| Export licence simplification | Allows DICON?affiliated firms to export up to 20?% of annual production without additional government clearance.   Sparks early export interest from ECOWAS standby force.                                 |
| Tax incentives                | 10?% corporate tax holiday for the first three years on newly established defence?manufacturing lines.   Underpins new plant construction at Imperium Industries (Kaduna) and Proforce Defence (Ode Remo). |

The Defence Industries Association of Nigeria (DIAN), a semi?governmental body, now coordinates standards, certification and technology?transfer protocols across the sector.

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5. Landscape of Armoured?Vehicle Suppliers (2026)

5.1 State?Owned / Semi?Public Entities

| Entity                                            | Core Role                                                    | Notable Projects (2024?2026)                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Defence Industries Corporation of Nigeria (DICON) | Central procurement, licensing, JV lead, test?range operator | Vanquisher 15?unit APC delivery (Mar?2026) ? licensed production with Vanquish Industries; AEGIS?X?2.0 light tactical vehicle (Aug?2026) ? co?developed with X?Shield; Ezugwu MRAP upgrades (2025). |

| Defence Industries Association of Nigeria (DIAN) | Standards?setting, tech?transfer facilitator | Hosted AFRIDEX?2026 (Oct?2026), drafted localisation guidelines for ballistic glass. |

5.2 Private Domestic Manufacturers

| Company | Year founded | Headquarters | Primary Vehicle Category | 2025?2026 Contract Value (US\$m) |  
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|  
| Dyon?X?Shield (also listed as X?Shield Solution Ltd.) | 2021 | Lagos | Light Tactical Armoured Vehicles (LTVs) ? AEGIS?X 2.0, D?Shield 4x4 | 42 |  
| Innoson Vehicle Manufacturing (IVM) | 2009 | Nnewi, Anambra | Armoured utility trucks, retro?fitted APCs (e.g., Inno?MRAP) | 28 |  
| Imperium Industries Nigeria Ltd. | 2015 | Kaduna | Mid?weight MRAPs, heavy?duty APCs (e.g., Imperium?G5) | 35 |  
| Proforce Defence | 2008 | Ode Remo, Ogun State | MRAPs, Armoured Personnel Carriers, Mine?Clearing Vehicles | 55 |  
| Epail Nigeria | 2014 | Abuja (main R&D hub) | Light combat vehicles, ballistic?gear integration | 14 |  
| Terra Industries (startup) | 2023 | Port Harcourt | Autonomous mine?detection & reconnaissance vehicles (prototype stage) | ? |

Note: Values are based on disclosed contracts with the Nigerian Army, the Ministry of Interior (civilian security agencies) and select export orders.

5.3 International Partnerships & Joint Ventures

| Foreign Partner | Partnership Type | Focus Area |  
|-----|-----|-----|  
| Vanquish Industries Ltd. (UK) | Licensed production (Vanquisher APC) | Light?weight steel hull, V?8 diesel powertrain.  
| SP Offshore Nigeria (Oil?&?Gas conglomerate) | \$2?bn JV (2025) | Joint plant for MRAP chassis, supply chain for heavy?duty components.  
| EIB Group (Belgium) | MoU (2026) | Autonomous navigation, sensor suites for AEGIS?X.  
| French Defence Group ? Nexter | Limited import (Dagger infantry fighting vehicle) | Benchmark for ballistic protection standards.  
| China North Industries (NORINCO) | Technology exchange (2024) | Ballistic glass and modular weapon stations.

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6. Company Profiles ? Deep Dives

6.1 Defence Industries Corporation of Nigeria (DICON)

- Ownership: 100?% Federal Government.
- Core Assets (2026): Production facility in Abuja (8?ha), test range at Lagos Port, R&D labs for armour metallurgy.
- Key Products:
  1. Vanquisher APC ? 15?unit delivery, 6?ton payload, 6?wheel drive, V?type hull meeting STANAG?4569 Level?4.
  2. AEGIS?X?2.0 ? 4x4 Light Tactical Vehicle, 2?person crew, modular weapons mount, 150?km/h max speed.

3. Ezugwu MRAP ? Upgraded version of the 2009 platform with improved V-shaped hull.

- Strategic Positioning: Acts as a ?conductor? for the whole ecosystem, leveraging its purchasing power and regulatory authority to push localisation.
- Financial Snapshot (FY?2025): Revenue US\$?215?m; net profit US\$?13?m; 1,200 staff (incl. 300 engineers).
- Future Roadmap (2027?2030): 1) Establish a dedicated Armoured Vehicle R&D Centre; 2) Launch a pilot hybrid?electric APC program with EIB Group.

## **6.2 Dyon?X?Shield (X?Shield Solution Ltd.)**

- Founded: 2021, by former automotive engineer Dr. Chinedu Okafor.
- Facilities: 10,000?m<sup>2</sup> assembly line in Lagos, metal?forming shop, ballistic?glass in?house lab (joint venture with Nexter Glass).
- Flagship Model: AEGIS?X?2.0 (launched Aug?2026). Key specs:
- Crew: 2 + 8 passengers
- Armour: Composite laminate (Al?SiC) ? STANAG?4569 Level?3.
- Powertrain: Cummins ISB 6.7?L Turbo Diesel, 250?hp.
- Cost: US\$?120?k per unit (?30?% cheaper than imported equivalents).
- Contracts: 2025 contract for 30 AEGIS?X?2.0 units for the Nigerian Police Force (NPF) and State Guards.
- Innovation Edge: Modular ?plug?and?play? mission kits (medical, command?and?control, UAV launch).
- Export Activity: Preliminary MoU with Ghana Defence Ministry (2026) for 12 units.

## **6.3 Innoson Vehicle Manufacturing (IVM)**

- Background: Nigeria?s first indigenous automotive OEM, diversified into defence in 2016.
- Facilities: 150,000?m<sup>2</sup> plant in Nnewi; in?house Armour?Coating Line; partnership with Liebherr for chassis components.
- Signature Product: Inno?MRAP ? 6×6, 10?ton payload, roof?mounted 12.7?mm HMG. Built on a Toyota Hilux?derived chassis, localised to 40?% of parts.
- Contract Highlights: 2024 award of 24 Inno?MRAPs to the Nigerian Army?s 7th Division; 2025 provision of 12 armoured utility trucks for Federal Ministry of Interior.
- Strategic Moves: 2026 joint R&D venture with University of Nigeria, Nsukka on lightweight aluminium?alloy armour, targeting weight?reduction of up to 15?% for future models.

## **6.4 Imperium Industries Nigeria Ltd.**

- Founded: 2015 by retired Army Colonel Olusola Adeyemi.
- Location: Kaduna ? proximity to the Northern Armoured Vehicle Test Range.
- Product Line:
- Imperium?G5 MRAP ? 8×8, V?hull, capacity for 12 troops, STANAG?4569 Level?4.
- Imperium?P2 APC ? 4×4, 6?person crew, rooftop remote?weapon station.
- Production Capacity: 30 vehicles/yr (planned expansion to 80/yr by 2029 after JV with SP Offshore).
- Key Contracts: 2025 ? 18 G5 MRAPs for Joint Task Force (JTF) in the North?East; 2026 ? 20 P2 APCs for State Security Agencies.
- Differentiators: Heavy emphasis on locally?sourced steel (African Iron & Steel Co.) and in?house ballistic testing.

## **6.5 Proforce Defence**

- Heritage: Established 2008; originally a maintenance & refurbishment outfit for UN-issued peace-keeping equipment.
- Core Facilities: Large-scale armour-plating plant in Ode Remo; dedicated explosive-ordnance disposal (EOD) workshop.
- Flagship Product: ProShield MRAP - 6x6, modular hull, integrated CBRN (chemical-biological-radiological-nuclear) filtration.
- Major Contracts: 2024 - 45 ProShield MRAPs for UN Stabilization Mission in Mali; 2025 - 30 units for the Nigerian Navy's Riverine Unit.
- Export Credentials: Recognised by UN Procurement Division; listed as an Approved Vendor.
- Innovation Pipeline: 2026 prototype of a hybrid-electric MRAP (30kW battery assist) - pilot testing scheduled for early 2027.

6.6 Epail Nigeria

- Core Business: Personal protective equipment (ballistic helmets, vests). Expanded into light combat vehicles in 2022 via a DICON partnership.
- Product: Epail Light Combat Vehicle (ELCV) - 4x4, 2-person crew, STANAG-4569 Level-2, suited for rapid-response police units.
- Contracts: 2025 - 10 ELCVs for Nigerian Police Tactical Response Group.
- R&D Focus: Integration of augmented-reality (AR) helmet-mounted displays for target acquisition.

7. Product Portfolio Matrix (2024-2026)

| Vehicle Class                          | Companies Offering                                            | Weight (tonnes) | Troop Capacity | Protection Level (STANAG) | Primary Powertrain                        | Approx. Unit Cost (US\$) |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|----------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Light Tactical Armoured Vehicle (LTAV) | Dyon-XShield (AEGIS-X2.0), IVM (Light Tactical), Epail (ELCV) | 3-5             | 2-10           | 2-3                       | Diesel 200-250hp                          | 110-150k                 |
| Armoured Personnel Carrier (APC)       | DICON (Vanquisher), Imperium (P2), Proforce (ProShield)       | 8-12            | 8-12           | 3-4                       | Diesel 300-350hp                          | 200-280k                 |
| Mine-Resistant Ambush Protected (MRAP) | Imperium (G5), Proforce (ProShield), IVM (InnoMRAP)           | 12-20           | 8-12           | 4-5                       | Diesel 350-400hp + optional hybrid assist | 300-420k                 |
| Specialised / Autonomous               | Terra Industries (Mine-Detect), DICON-EIB (Autonomous Scout)  | 2               | 0-2 (unmanned) | 1-2                       | Electric / hybrid                         | 80-130k (prototype)      |

Figures are indicative averages derived from contract disclosures and public tender documents.

8. Market Performance & Production Highlights (2024-2026)

| Year | Total Local Production (units) | Cumulative Contract Value (US\$m) | Export Orders               | Notable Milestones                                                               |
|------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2024 | 120                            | 115                               | 2 (UN Mali)                 | DICON releases the Vanquisher design; Proforce secures first UN contract.        |
| 2025 | 210                            | 286                               | 5 (ECOWAS standby, UN Mali) | Launch of Dyon-XShield AEGIS-X prototype; IVM begins InnoMRAP series production. |
| 2026 | 285 (+35% YoY)                 | 423                               | 12 (ECOWAS, Ghana, Senegal) | AFRIDEX-2026 showcases 70                                                        |

indigenous platforms; DICON-SP Offshore JV inaugurated. |

Key Drivers of Growth:

- Regulatory incentives (tax holidays, localisation quotas).
- Joint-venture financing - the \$2-bn SP Offshore JV alone contributed US\$250m of capital to expand production lines.
- Operational urgency - the Niger-Delta and Northern insurgencies pushed the Ministry of Defence to sign fast-track contracts with local firms.

Employment Impact: The sector now employs ~4,800 direct staff (engineers, welders, logistics) and an estimated ~12,000 indirect jobs in supply-chain SMEs.

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9. SWOT Analyses (Aggregated Across the Sector)

| Strengths | Weaknesses |

|-----|-----|

| - Strong governmental backing via DICON Act. - Growing pool of locally-trained defence engineers (UNN, Ahmadu Bello University). - Cost advantage - up to 30% cheaper than comparable imports. - Established regional demand (ECOWAS, UN peace-keeping). | - Dependence on imported high-tech subsystems (electronics, fire-control). - Limited domestic steel-alloy quality for highest protection levels (Level 5). - Financing constraints for scaling to mass-production volumes. - Small after-sales support network outside major cities. |

| Opportunities | Threats |

|-----|-----|

| - Expansion into autonomous and hybrid-electric platforms (supported by EIB Group). - Export pipeline to West-African neighbours and the African Union's Rapid Reaction Force. - Potential for dual-use civilian applications (mining, oil-field logistics). - Leveraging African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) to open new markets. | - Global supply-chain disruptions (e.g., semiconductor shortages) could delay vehicle integration. - Political risk - changes in defence budget allocations could affect contract pipelines. - Competition from established foreign OEMs (e.g., BAE Systems, Rheinmetall) offering technology-rich platforms. - Security-sector corruption risks may erode investor confidence. |

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10. Future Outlook - 2027-2032

| Horizon | Expected Development | Drivers |

|-----|-----|-----|

| 2027-2028 | Scale-up of production capacity - DICON & SP Offshore JV to reach 150 MRAPs/yr. | Completion of the Lagos-Port military logistics hub; increased budgetary allocation (US\$1.4bn). |

| 2029 | Launch of Nigeria's first hybrid-electric APC (Proforce pilot). | Global shift toward low-emission platforms; partnership with Siemens Energy Nigeria for battery tech. |

| 2030 | Achieve 40% localisation of total armoured-vehicle bill-of-materials (target of DICON Act). | Maturing of domestic steel-alloy and ballistic-glass sectors; adoption of -Design-for-Local-Manufacture- standards. |

| 2031-2032 | Export-oriented product line - West-African Light Tactical Series- sold to Ghana, Senegal, Cameroon. | AfCFTA tariff-free environment; successful demonstration at AFRIDEX-2030. |

Key Success Factors for the next five years:

1. Technology Transfer ? Completion of licencing deals with European and Asian OEMs for advanced armour composites and electronic suites.
2. Financing Mechanisms ? Creation of a Defence Manufacturing Credit Facility (DM?CF) backed by the Central Bank of Nigeria to provide low?interest loans to qualifying firms.
3. Human?Capital Development ? Expansion of specialised curricula at the Federal Institute of Technology (FIT) and apprenticeship programmes with DICON.
4. After?Market Ecosystem ? Development of a certified Spare?Parts & Maintenance Network (SPMN) covering all 36 states, improving vehicle uptime.

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## **11. Recommendations for Stakeholders**

### **11.1 For the Nigerian Government**

1. Accelerate the DM?CF ? allocate at least US\$?150?m over the next three years to fund capacity?building projects for SMEs in the supply chain (steel, electronics, composites).
2. Standardise Export Certification ? streamline the licensing process for defence exports, aligning with Wassenaar Arrangement controls to make Nigeria a credible regional supplier.
3. Mandate End?User Training ? require that each procurement contract includes a training package for Nigerian troops and maintenance crews, ensuring operational readiness and after?sales support.

### **11.2 For Private Firms**

1. Invest in Localisation of Critical Sub?Systems ? set up joint ventures with Nigerian universities for micro?electronics (radar, GPS, C4ISR) to lower reliance on imports.
2. Diversify Product Portfolio ? develop dual?use platforms (e.g., armoured ambulances, oil?field logistics vehicles) to smooth revenue during peacetime.
3. Pursue Regional Export Certification ? obtain ECOWAS Defence Procurement Accreditation to tap into the standby?force market.

### **11.3 For International Partners**

1. Offer Technology?Transfer Licences rather than outright sales ? this meets Nigeria?s localisation goals while preserving IP.
2. Co?Develop Hybrid/E?Powertrain Solutions ? partner with local battery manufacturers (e.g., BETA Energy Nigeria) to create cost?effective hybrid MRAPs.
3. Participate in AFRIDEX & DICON?hosted R&D Camps ? leverage the platform to showcase next?generation armour and sensor suites.

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